

1. Analyze the Social Context that Caused the Birth of Kannada Novels (10)

The emergence of the Kannada novel was not a sudden literary development but the result of deep social, cultural, and historical changes in Karnataka during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Before this period, Kannada literature was largely dominated by poetry, religious texts, epics, and oral narrative forms. Prose fiction, especially the novel, was not considered a serious literary form.

One of the most important factors behind the rise of the Kannada novel was **colonial influence**. British rule introduced Western education and new literary forms through English. Educated Kannada writers came into contact with English novels and realist prose, which inspired them to experiment with long narrative fiction in their own language.

The **growth of print culture** also played a major role. Printing presses, newspapers, journals, and magazines created a new reading public, especially among the urban middle class. Readers began to demand literature that reflected their social realities rather than mythological or religious themes.

At the same time, **social reform movements** were gaining momentum. Issues such as caste oppression, women's education, widow remarriage, child marriage, and social inequality became central concerns. Writers found the novel to be an effective medium to discuss these issues in detail and to influence public opinion.

Urbanisation and the rise of a modern middle class further contributed to this shift. Thus, the Kannada novel was born out of a changing society that required new literary forms to express modern experiences and social consciousness.

2. Write an Essay on Partition Novels in Hindi (10)

Partition novels in Hindi literature occupy a significant place because they deal with one of the most traumatic events in Indian history—the Partition of India in 1947. Unlike political histories, these novels focus on the **human suffering** caused by Partition, such as communal violence, displacement, loss of home, and psychological trauma.

Hindi writers like **Yashpal, Bhisham Sahni, Krishna Sobti, Kamleshwar, and Amrita Pritam** portrayed Partition as a deeply tragic and senseless event. Bhisham Sahni's *Tamas* is one of the most powerful Partition novels, showing how communal hatred and political manipulation destroy innocent lives.

A recurring theme in these novels is **displacement and loss of identity**. Refugees are shown struggling to rebuild their lives in unfamiliar environments. Partition novels also highlight the moral confusion and breakdown of human values during times of violence.

Women's suffering occupies a central place in Hindi Partition narratives. Abduction, sexual violence, and loss of dignity reveal the gendered nature of Partition trauma.

Rather than celebrating independence, Hindi Partition novels question the cost of freedom and preserve the memory of collective suffering for future generations.

3. Write a Note on the Growth of Contemporary Indian Theatre (10)

Contemporary Indian theatre represents a major shift from traditional and classical forms of drama. It emerged in response to changing social realities and the need to address modern issues such as political corruption, gender inequality, violence, identity, and marginalisation.

Playwrights like **Badal Sircar, Girish Karnad, Vijay Tendulkar, Mohan Rakesh, and Mahesh Dattani** played a crucial role in shaping contemporary Indian theatre. Badal Sircar introduced street theatre and minimalistic staging, making theatre accessible to common people.

Girish Karnad used myths and historical narratives to explore contemporary concerns, while Vijay Tendulkar focused on power structures, oppression, and social hypocrisy. Mahesh Dattani addressed urban middle-class issues using English drama.

Contemporary theatre also experimented with form and technique. Symbolism, non-linear narratives, and minimal sets became common. Thus, contemporary Indian theatre grew as a socially engaged and experimental art form.

4. What Are the Aims of Dalit Writing and How Well Does *Karukku* Achieve Them? (10)

Dalit writing emerged as a protest literature aimed at expressing the lived experiences of communities oppressed by the caste system. One of its primary aims is to **expose caste-based discrimination, humiliation, and injustice** that are often ignored in mainstream literature.

Dalit literature also seeks to reclaim dignity, self-respect, and identity. It challenges upper-caste dominance and demands equality and social justice. Authentic experience is valued more than aesthetic polish.

Bama's *Karukku* effectively achieves these aims. Written as an autobiographical narrative, it presents everyday experiences of discrimination faced by Dalits, especially within educational and religious institutions. The use of simple, direct language rooted in lived experience adds to its power.

Karukku is both a personal testimony and a collective voice, making it a successful and influential work of Dalit literature.

5. "'Salt' Combines Stringent Political Comment with Sophisticated Literary Technique." Discuss. (10)

'Salt' is a text that successfully balances political commitment with artistic sophistication. The political dimension of the work lies in its critique of power structures, injustice, and exploitation. However, the text avoids direct propaganda or ideological preaching.

Instead, political ideas are conveyed through **symbolism, irony, and narrative subtlety**. Characters and situations reflect broader social realities, allowing readers to engage critically with the issues presented.

From a literary perspective, the text employs refined language, controlled structure, and layered meanings. These techniques ensure that the work remains aesthetically satisfying while being politically meaningful.

Thus, 'Salt' stands as an example of how literature can be politically engaged without sacrificing artistic quality.

6. Do You Think 'Birds' Ends on a Happy Note? Give Reasons. (10)

'Birds' does not end on a clearly happy note, though it offers a sense of emotional resolution. The ending is **open-ended and reflective**, leaving room for interpretation.

While there may be a sense of acceptance or understanding among the characters, deeper conflicts remain unresolved. The image of birds symbolises freedom and aspiration, but also uncertainty and fragility.

Rather than providing a neat or optimistic conclusion, the story reflects the complexity of human emotions and relationships. Therefore, the ending is realistic rather than conventionally happy.

7. Comment on the Style and Symbolism in 'The Empty Chest' (10)

'The Empty Chest' is marked by a restrained and understated narrative style. The language is simple and controlled, allowing emotional depth to emerge gradually rather than through dramatic expression.

The central symbol of the empty chest represents **loss, absence, and emotional emptiness**. It stands for memories, relationships, or hopes that can no longer be recovered.

Silence, pauses, and minimal description are important stylistic features. These techniques enhance the symbolic meaning and emotional impact of the story.

8. Discuss 'The Compromise' as an Allegory (10)

'The Compromise' can be interpreted as an allegory that represents broader moral, social, or political dilemmas. The act of compromise symbolises the **surrender of principles under pressure**.

Characters function not just as individuals but as representatives of larger forces such as authority, fear, and conformity. The story critiques how people often justify moral failure in the name of survival or convenience.

Through allegory, the text delivers a strong ethical message without becoming overtly didactic.

9. Discuss the Thematics and Poetic Style of 'Tree and the Sage' (10)

'Tree and the Sage' explores themes of wisdom, humility, and harmony with nature. The poem contrasts human intellectual pride with the silent wisdom of nature.

The tree symbolises rootedness, patience, and continuity, while the sage represents the human search for knowledge. The interaction suggests that true wisdom lies in humility and balance.

The poetic style is simple, meditative, and symbolic, drawing upon Indian philosophical traditions. The language is calm and reflective, enhancing the poem's spiritual tone.

10. How Does a Late 20th or 21st Century Reader Accept the Re-invention of the Myth of Sri Radha? (10)

A late twentieth or twenty-first century reader generally accepts the re-invention of the myth of Sri Radha as a **creative reinterpretation rather than a distortion** of tradition. Modern writers portray Radha not only as a devotional figure but also as a woman with emotional depth and individual agency.

This re-visioning allows contemporary readers to connect myth with modern concerns such as identity, desire, and freedom. The myth becomes relevant to present-day social and emotional realities.

Thus, modern readers view the reinvention of Radha as a meaningful dialogue between tradition and modernity.